

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

MAKING YOUTH EMPLOYABLE

To cash in on its demographic advantage, India must revamp its skilling infrastructure with aid from the industry

By SONAL KHETARPAL

JAYANT CHAUDHARY, *45* | RLD
Minister of State (Independent Charge) of the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship

Illustrious forebears
↘ A grandson of former prime minister Chaudhary Charan Singh and son of former minister Ajit Singh, Jayant did his post-graduation from the London School of Economics. He was MP from Mathura from 2009 to 2014. His Rashtriya Lok Dal joined the NDA ahead of the 2024 LS polls after the government honoured his grandfather with the Bharat Ratna

Depth of engagement
↘ Jayant has been a member of the Standing Committee on commerce, agriculture and finance, the Consultative Committee on Finance and the Committee on Government Assurances

Each year, 12 million people are added to the working age population in India, representing a vast pool of potential workers that could see the country reaping a demographic dividend. However, unemployment is rife even among the educated youth. According to the India Employment Report 2024, the share of youth in the total unemployed populace is a staggering 82.9 per cent. The government launched the Skill India mission with much fanfare in 2015, but the focus of training institutes has been on skilling rather than employment. Government data shows that under the Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY) 2.0, between FY17 and FY23 (as of January 5, 2023), over ten million people have been trained, of which just over two million got jobs. This alarming statistic revives fears that India may be losing out on its demographic dividend. "Skilling cannot be an afterthought; it must be integrated with our formal education system, from the secondary level onwards. The industry must lead the way in training," says Jayant Krishna, former CEO and COO of the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC). ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

GROUP OF SKILLS
Mainstream education must integrate employability skills right from the secondary level. Courses on life skills, language proficiency, communication skills and professional ethics could be included

PUSH FOR APPRENTICESHIP
The National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme must be encouraged so that trainees get the opportunity to learn on the job. Since the programme's launch in 2016, only 2.47 million apprentices were engaged by industries till November 2023. A six-month apprenticeship could be integrated into all undergraduate degrees to boost graduate employability

INDUSTRY INVOLVEMENT
This should be encouraged either through subsidies or CSR funds. Industry expertise is crucial for high-quality, market-relevant training. Skilling, everyone agrees, must be driven by the needs of industry